The Planet’s Vote

WORLD DEMOCRATIC PLATFORM

A Framework for Planetary-Scale Direct Democracy

White Paper — Version 1.7

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> *The greatest threats to humanity — supervolcanic eruption, asteroid impact, pandemic, climate collapse — do not respect national borders. Yet our systems of governance remain fractured by exactly those borders. The Planet’s Vote proposes a solution: a single, incorruptible, planetary-scale democratic platform through which every human being on Earth may exercise their voice on the issues that affect all of us equally.*

Executive Summary

The Planet’s Vote is a proposed global direct-democracy platform enabling every adult human being on Earth to vote on planetary-scale issues. It operates on a demand-triggered quarterly voting schedule — votes are called when verified individuals signal sufficient support for ratified questions — and requires a supermajority threshold of 66.7% for any resolution to pass, ensuring that no bare majority can impose decisions on a near-equal minority.

For issues of existential or planetary-class urgency — asteroid impacts, supervolcanic eruptions, pandemic emergence, or ecological collapse — the platform incorporates an Emergency Override Protocol allowing a crisis vote to open within six hours of verified threat confirmation, bypassing the standard quarterly schedule.

World Government Representatives are elected by regional supermajority and serve as the executive layer that translates passed resolutions into coordinated international action. All representatives require a minimum 66.7% mandate to hold office, with constitutional changes requiring an 80% threshold.

The platform is built on five technical pillars: decentralised self-sovereign identity verification, zero-knowledge voting proofs, open-source auditable code, blockchain vote confirmation, and a geographically distributed hosting infrastructure resistant to single-nation shutdown.

This white paper sets out the philosophical foundation, governance architecture, technical design, legal pathway, and implementation roadmap for The Planet’s Vote. It is submitted as a living document, open to collaboration from governance scholars, technologists, legal experts, and democratic theorists worldwide.

Key Metric	Target
Eligible voters at launch	~5.2 billion adults globally
Supermajority threshold	66.7% (two-thirds) of participating voters
Crisis vote threshold	75% of participating voters
Constitutional threshold	80% of participating voters
Voting cycle	Quarterly (maximum four votes per year, demand-triggered)
Issues per cycle	Minimum 2, maximum 5 per quarterly vote + emergency overrides
Identity standard	Self-sovereign, biometric-verified, zero-knowledge
Representative term	Approximately one year
Minimum participation for validity	20% of registered voters globally

Part I: The Problem — Why Nations Cannot Solve Planetary Problems

1.1 The Structural Failure of Nation-State Governance

The nation-state is a remarkable human invention — a mechanism for organising collective decision-making across populations of millions. But it was designed for a world in which the most consequential threats were local or regional: invasion, famine, disease within borders. The 21st century has rendered that assumption obsolete.

The five greatest threats to human civilisation — supervolcanic eruption, asteroid or comet impact, pandemic, irreversible climate change, and the misaligned development of artificial general intelligence — share a single defining characteristic: they are indifferent to national borders. A Yellowstone eruption does not pause at the Canadian border. An asteroid does not negotiate with the UN Security Council. A novel pathogen does not check passports.

Yet our decision-making architecture remains profoundly national. The United Nations, the most ambitious attempt at international coordination in human history, operates by consensus among sovereign states. Decision-making at the required scale requires broad agreement among member states — a process that, by its nature, moves at a pace calibrated to diplomacy rather than to the urgency of planetary threats. The Planet’s Vote does not propose to change this architecture. It proposes to add a new layer alongside it: a direct democratic mandate from the people of Earth that can inform and support the decisions these institutions must make.

Historical Precedent

The closest analogues to what The Planet’s Vote proposes are the Antarctic Treaty System (1959), which placed an entire continent under cooperative international governance, and the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (1968). Both demonstrated that nations can cede a narrow domain of sovereignty when the existential stakes are sufficiently clear. The Planet’s Vote extends this logic to its natural conclusion: a permanent, democratic mechanism for planetary governance on defined categories of global concern.

1.2 The Democratic Deficit in International Institutions

Existing international bodies were designed for a world that has changed profoundly since their founding. The structures of global governance that emerged in the mid-twentieth century reflect the geopolitical realities of that era, and have served important purposes in maintaining international cooperation and stability. The question The Planet’s Vote asks is not whether these institutions have value — they do — but whether they are sufficient, alone, for the scale and speed of the planetary challenges now facing humanity. The Planet’s Vote is designed to complement them, not to replace them, by providing something none of them currently possess: a direct, verified democratic mandate from the people of Earth.

The Planet’s Vote does not propose to replace these institutions. It proposes to give them something none of them currently possess: a legitimate, direct democratic mandate from the human population of Earth. A resolution passed by 70% of participating voters across all regions of the world carries a moral and political authority that no treaty negotiated between governments can match. These institutions would retain their operational expertise and existing authority — The Planet’s Vote would provide the democratic legitimacy that authorises them to act on behalf of all of humanity.

1.3 The Two Most Neglected Existential Threats

Supervolcanic Eruption

At least 20 supervolcanic systems worldwide are capable of eruptions orders of magnitude larger than any in recorded history. A Yellowstone-class eruption would inject sufficient sulphur dioxide into the upper atmosphere to reduce global temperatures by 5-10 degrees Celsius for three to seven years — collapsing agriculture, triggering famine at civilisational scale, and potentially killing billions of people within a decade of the event.

Current mitigation research is critically underfunded. No coordinated international programme exists to extract heat from any supervolcanic system. NASA has published preliminary proposals for deep geothermal drilling at Yellowstone, projecting that a network of boreholes could reduce eruption probability by up to 72% over a century at an estimated cost of $3.46 billion — a sum roughly equivalent to three days of global military spending. The absence of such a programme is not a technical failure. It is a governance failure.

Near-Earth Object Impact

The most tractable of the planetary existential threats is also the one where governance has advanced furthest and stalled most conspicuously. NASA's DART mission in 2022 demonstrated that kinetic deflection of an asteroid is not science fiction — it works. We know what to do. We lack only the institutional framework to authorise doing it at planetary scale.

The International Asteroid Warning Network (IAWN) and the Space Mission Planning Advisory Group (SMPAG) exist as voluntary coordination bodies with no binding authority and no dedicated funding. The 1967 Outer Space Treaty restricts the use of nuclear devices in space — a restriction that may need revisiting for large-object deflection scenarios. None of these gaps can be closed without a legitimate global decision-making authority. The Planet’s Vote provides exactly that authority.

Part II: The Solution — Architecture of The Planet’s Vote

2.1 Foundational Principles

The Planet’s Vote is built on seven foundational principles that distinguish it from all prior attempts at international democratic governance:

Principle	Definition	Implication
One Person, One Vote	Every adult human being has exactly equal voting weight regardless of nationality, wealth, or geography.	No nation's citizens count more than any other's.
Supermajority Legitimacy	No resolution passes without 66.7% of participating voters. Crisis and constitutional thresholds are higher.	Prevents bare-majority tyranny on planetary decisions.
Radical Transparency	Every line of code, every algorithmic parameter, every vote count is publicly auditable in real time.	Eliminates the possibility of hidden manipulation.
Cryptographic Privacy	Zero-knowledge proofs guarantee that individual votes cannot be identified or coerced.	Separates verifiability from identifiability.
Geographic Sovereignty	No single nation can shut down the platform. Infrastructure is distributed across jurisdictions.	Prevents authoritarian capture.
Scientific Grounding	The trending algorithm weights peer-reviewed scientific consensus for empirical questions.	Prevents misinformation from capturing the global agenda.
Subsidiarity	The Planet’s Vote votes only on issues that genuinely require planetary-level coordination. All other matters remain with nations, regions, and communities.	Prevents global overreach into local affairs.

2.2 The Demand-Triggered Voting Model

The Planet’s Vote does not operate on a fixed calendar. Votes are triggered by the demonstrated will of registered individuals — not by the passage of time. This demand-triggered model replaces the earlier lunar cycle schedule for two reasons: it reduces voter fatigue by ensuring that votes are called only when a sufficient number of people genuinely want them, and it ensures that each vote feels consequential rather than routine.

Votes are held on a quarterly schedule — a maximum of four times per year. When the threshold conditions described below are met, the questions that have crossed the threshold are held for the next quarterly vote. This gives voters a predictable rhythm while ensuring that no single well-organised campaign can force a vote on short notice. The Emergency Override Protocol operates entirely outside this quarterly schedule.

2.2.1 How Questions Are Proposed

Any verified individual registered voter may propose a question for consideration. Organisations, corporations, governments, and institutions may not propose questions — only individual human beings. This principle is non-negotiable.

The reason is straightforward. An employee whose employer proposes a question they personally oppose should not face retaliation for registering a contrary view. A scientist whose institution takes a position they disagree with should not be silenced. The moment organisations are permitted to propose or vote, the platform recreates the power imbalances it was designed to overcome. A corporation with a hundred thousand employees could flood the signal queue. A government could direct its civil servants. The Planet’s Vote is a platform of individuals, by individuals, for the planet.

Proposed questions are submitted through the platform and enter a review queue. The proposer must be a verified registered voter. Multiple individuals may co-propose a question, but each counts as one signal.

2.2.2 Scientific Ratification by Individuals

Before a proposed question enters the active signal queue, it must pass a scientific ratification process. This process is conducted by individual scientists and researchers — verified as individuals with relevant expertise in the question's subject domain — not by institutions or organisations acting as bodies.

This distinction is deliberate. Scientists working within institutions are subject to the same organisational pressures as any other professional. A researcher at a climate institute whose employer has taken a public position on a question should be free to evaluate that question on its scientific merits as an individual, without their institution's endorsement being required or their disagreement being professionally costly. Individual scientists who participate in The Planet’s Vote's ratification process do so as citizens of the planet, not as representatives of their employers.

The ratification process serves two purposes only:

- Scientific soundness: is the question grounded in scientific evidence, or does it misrepresent the state of knowledge? Questions that are factually incoherent or based on demonstrably false premises are returned to the proposer with an explanation.
- Plain language phrasing: is the question intelligible to a person with no specialist background? Questions that require technical knowledge to understand are rephrased — in consultation with the proposer — into language accessible to any adult on Earth.

Ratification is not a political gatekeeping function. A question that is scientifically coherent and clearly phrased must be admitted to the signal queue, regardless of how politically uncomfortable its implications may be. The ratification body has no authority to suppress a valid question on the grounds that it dislikes the answer a supermajority might give.

Individual scientific reviewers are volunteers. They participate because the questions matter to them as human beings. The Planet’s Vote does not require institutional affiliations to participate in ratification — it requires demonstrated expertise, which may be evidenced through peer-reviewed publication, professional qualification, or other verifiable means.

2.2.3 The Signal Threshold — Phased by Registration

Once a question is ratified, it enters the active signal queue. Any registered voter may signal support for any question in the queue. Signalling is not voting — it is an expression of the view that this question deserves a formal vote. One person, one signal, per question.

The threshold required to trigger a formal vote is phased in proportion to the registered voter base, to ensure the platform can demonstrate real function during its early phase while scaling appropriately as it grows:

- Phase 1 — Registered voter base under 1 million: threshold is 100,000 individual signals.
- Phase 2 — Registered voter base between 1 million and 50 million: threshold is 1 million individual signals. This represents approximately 2% of the maximum Phase 2 base.
- Phase 3 — Registered voter base over 50 million: threshold is 2% of total registered voters. At a fully registered global electorate of approximately 5.5 billion adults, this equates to approximately 110 million individual signals — a number that dwarfs any petition or popular mandate in recorded history.

The 2% rate is maintained consistently across Phase 2 and Phase 3, providing continuity and predictability as the platform grows. The threshold is always calculated against the registered voter base at the time the question crosses it.

2.2.4 Triggering a Vote

A quarterly vote is called when a minimum of two ratified questions have each independently reached the signal threshold. A maximum of five questions may appear on any single quarterly ballot. If more than five questions have crossed the threshold in the same period, the five with the highest signal counts proceed to the vote; the others queue for the following quarter.

The minimum of two questions per vote serves an important purpose: it prevents a single well-organised campaign from dominating the vote calendar and ensures that the democratic event feels like a genuine planetary conversation across multiple issues rather than a single-issue referendum.

Once the threshold conditions are met, the vote opens at the next scheduled quarterly date. The target preparation window is 90 days from threshold to vote opening — sufficient time for voters to consider the questions, for plain-language summaries to be translated into major world languages, and for the platform to communicate the upcoming vote to all registered voters. This window may be extended in exceptional circumstances — armed conflict, pandemic, or natural disaster significantly affecting the platform's ability to reach voters — but any extension and its reason must be publicly announced.

2.2.5 Question Lifespan and Archive

Questions do not expire. A question that has been ratified and entered the signal queue remains active indefinitely. There is no deadline by which a question must cross the threshold or be discarded.

After one year in the active queue without crossing the threshold, a question moves to the The Planet’s Vote Archive. The archive is publicly visible and remains active — any registered voter may continue to add their signal to archived questions at any time. If an archived question subsequently crosses the threshold, it returns to the active queue and proceeds to the next quarterly vote.

This design reflects a deliberate principle: a question that fails to reach threshold in its first year may become more relevant in its third year as the platform grows, as the underlying issue becomes more acute, or as more of the world registers. Democratic momentum should never be discarded. Questions wait; they do not die.

The archive also serves a historical function, recording the evolving concerns of registered voters over time and providing a public record of what humanity has considered worth discussing at planetary scale.

The demand-triggered model is designed around a single principle: that a planetary vote should happen when people genuinely want it, not because a calendar says so. The quarterly cadence provides rhythm and predictability. The signal threshold ensures that only questions with demonstrated planetary-scale concern reach the ballot. And the archive ensures that no legitimate concern is ever permanently silenced for failing to reach threshold at a particular moment in time.

2.4 Emergency Override Protocol

For threats of planetary-class urgency, the standard quarterly schedule is suspended. The Emergency Override Protocol allows a crisis vote to open within six hours of a verified threat confirmation, provided the confirmation meets the following criteria:

- Independent verification by at least three internationally recognised scientific institutions
- Classification of the threat as planetary-class by the World Government Science Advisory Panel
- Formal notification to all registered voters via the platform's emergency broadcast system

Crisis votes remain open for 48 hours. The supermajority threshold is raised to 75% to reflect the gravity of the decision and the reduced deliberation time. Crisis resolutions authorise the World Government Council to act immediately with the resources and mandate specified in the resolution.

> *The Emergency Override Protocol is not a mechanism for bypassing democracy — it is a mechanism for exercising democracy at the speed that existential threats demand. Every crisis vote remains subject to the supermajority threshold. The difference is time, not legitimacy.*

2.5 World Government Council

The World Government Council is the executive body of The Planet’s Vote — the mechanism through which passed resolutions are translated into coordinated international action. It is not a sovereign government. It has no authority to legislate beyond the mandates passed to it by the voting population. It is, in essence, the world's largest collective executive.

The Council consists of 17 Regional Representatives elected by supermajority vote within their regions, plus a Secretary-General elected by global supermajority vote. Representatives serve terms of approximately one year. Any representative whose approval rating falls below 55% in a mid-term confidence vote faces a recall election.

The Council's authority is strictly bounded: it may only act on resolutions that have passed the 66.7% supermajority threshold. It may not initiate action on any matter not explicitly mandated by a passed resolution. It reports publicly and in full on all actions taken in execution of passed resolutions.

Part III: Technical Architecture

3.1 The Identity Layer — The Foundational Problem

The single most technically challenging component of The Planet’s Vote is the identity layer: the mechanism by which the platform verifies that every voter is a real, unique human being, without creating a centralised database that can be corrupted, hacked, or weaponised by any government or corporate actor.

This is not merely a technical challenge — it is a philosophical and political one. Any identity system that relies on government-issued credentials reproduces the power imbalances of the existing state system. Any system that relies on a private corporation introduces a single point of failure and a profit motive misaligned with democratic integrity. The Planet’s Vote requires a third path.

The Ring VRF Architecture

Following detailed technical analysis of the available approaches to ZK-based identity at scale, The Planet’s Vote adopts the Ring Verifiable Random Function (ring VRF) with registered public key as its recommended identity architecture. This approach — formalised in a 2023 paper by researchers at the Web3 Foundation and implemented in the Polkadot ecosystem — provides the optimal balance of the required properties.

The mechanism works as follows. Each voter registers once by generating a zero-knowledge proof (SNARK) of their ePassport — proving possession of a valid government-issued biometric document without revealing any of its contents. This registration creates a fresh public key that is entered into a ring of all registered voter keys. The raw ePassport data is never stored. Subsequent voting uses this ring VRF key to cast anonymous votes: the system can verify the vote comes from a registered unique human, but cannot determine which registered human cast it.

This approach solves three of the four key problems identified in prior ZK voting research:

- **Electricity efficiency:** registration generates one proof once; subsequent votes are computationally lightweight.
- **Anonymity:** ring signatures make it cryptographically impossible to link a vote to a specific registered identity.
- **Verifiable uniqueness:** the nullifier mechanism ensures each registered key can only vote once per cycle, without revealing which key voted.

The vote-selling problem. Vote-selling resistance is an active research focus for The Planet’s Vote. This challenge is not unique to the ring VRF architecture — it is a feature of all remote voting systems, including established national e-voting platforms. Swiss Post’s e-voting system, the most rigorously audited operational e-voting platform currently in production, demonstrates in practice that the same security principles The Planet’s Vote is designing toward are achievable: end-to-end encryption, cryptographic vote-mixing that prevents any inference between a voter’s identity and their vote, tamper-proof audit logs, and administrator-proof architecture. The Planet’s Vote is actively seeking collaboration with Swiss Post’s Cryptography Center to inform the technical implementation of these principles in a planetary-scale context. The social and legal framework surrounding The Planet’s Vote treats vote-selling as a violation of the platform’s founding charter, complementing technical protections with institutional and legal safeguards.

Existing Implementations

A critical advance since the original drafting of this white paper is that the core technical components of The Planet’s Vote’s identity layer are no longer theoretical. Multiple open-source implementations now exist:

- **zkPassport:** An open-source implementation that reads ePassport NFC chips and generates ZK proofs of personhood without revealing passport contents. Already functional on standard NFC-capable smartphones. See zkpassport.id.
- **Google Longfellow ZKP:** Google open-sourced its zero-knowledge proof libraries in July 2025, specifically designed for privacy-preserving identity verification at scale. Available at github.com/google/longfellow-zk.
- **EU eIDAS ZKP Wallet:** The European Union’s eIDAS regulation, taking effect in 2026, mandates ZKP integration into the European Digital Identity Wallet — providing government-backed ZK identity infrastructure for over 440 million citizens.
- **Human Passport (formerly Gitcoin Passport):** A modular proof-of-personhood system combining ZK-powered passport verification, on-chain reputation, and multiple identity pathways. Already deployed with millions of users. See human.tech.

The ePassport Coverage Gap

The ring VRF ePassport approach has one significant structural limitation: global passport ownership is uneven. Coverage varies substantially by country and income level, with lower rates in parts of sub-Saharan Africa, South Asia, and the Pacific. A system requiring an ePassport would structurally exclude a significant portion of humanity — precisely the populations that existing governance systems already marginalise.

This gap is acknowledged honestly and addressed through the parallel identity pathways described below. The ring VRF ePassport pathway is the primary and most cryptographically robust route; it is not the only route. All pathways produce an identical ZK credential upon registration. The platform cannot distinguish, and does not record, which pathway any individual used.

Parallel Identity Pathways

The Planet’s Vote mandates multiple parallel pathways to identity registration. No single method is compulsory. The platform is designed so that neither physical capability nor document availability determines whether a person can participate in planetary democracy.

Pathway 1 — ePassport ZK Registration (Primary): Using a smartphone’s NFC reader, the voter’s ePassport chip is read and a ZK proof is generated locally on the device. No passport data leaves the device. The proof is submitted to the registration network, which verifies uniqueness and issues a ring VRF key. This pathway is available to anyone with an NFC-enabled smartphone and a biometric passport.

Pathway 2 — Community Attestation Network: For people without ePassports or NFC-capable devices, a network of in-person community verification centres — particularly in low-connectivity regions and in communities with high rates of disability — where trained facilitators assist with registration. Community attestation uses a web-of-trust model: existing verified voters can attest to the identity of new registrants, with cryptographic safeguards against attestation fraud.

Pathway 3 — Scramble-Pad PIN with Supervised Registration: For people who cannot use biometric scanning or NFC due to physical disability, a randomised PIN entry system — a scramble pad — where numeric positions change with every use, defeating shoulder-surfing and recording attacks. Registration is conducted once through an assisted process. This pathway was identified by The Planet’s Vote’s founder, Paul Innes — a quadriplegic who cannot use standard biometric methods — as an essential accessibility requirement.

Pathway 4 — Adaptive Interface and Voice Access: The The Planet’s Vote voting interface is designed to be fully operable by voice command, switch access, and other assistive technologies. The UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities establishes participation in political and public life as a fundamental right. The Planet’s Vote treats this not as a compliance obligation but as a design principle.

All pathways produce a cryptographically identical ZK credential. The platform cannot distinguish between them. A vote cast through Pathway 3 is indistinguishable from a vote cast through Pathway 1 in every respect except the registration mechanism. The democratic weight is equal.

Uniqueness Binding

Across all pathways, the core guarantee is uniqueness binding: the cryptographic assurance that each registered credential corresponds to exactly one living human being, and that no person can register more than once. This is achieved through:

- Nullifier mechanisms that detect and reject duplicate registrations without revealing the identity of the duplicate
- Cross-pathway deduplication proofs that prevent the same person from registering through multiple pathways
- Revocation protocols that allow credentials to be invalidated if fraud is detected, without disrupting the anonymity of legitimate voters

The identity layer is The Planet’s Vote’s hardest unsolved engineering problem. This white paper sets out the architecture with honesty about what is currently implemented (the shadow vote platform), what is technically available in open-source form (zkPassport, Longfellow ZKP, Human Passport), and what remains to be built (the full ring VRF registration and voting integration at planetary scale). The Planet’s Vote invites cryptographers, identity researchers, and governance technologists to engage with this problem directly.

3.2 The Voting Layer

Votes on The Planet’s Vote are cast, recorded, and tallied using a protocol that satisfies four simultaneous requirements that are in tension with each other in conventional voting systems:

- Anonymity: no individual vote can be traced to a specific voter
- Verifiability: every voter can verify their own vote was correctly recorded
- Universal verifiability: any observer can verify the correctness of the overall tally
- Coercion-resistance: no voter can prove how they voted to a third party, substantially reducing the viability of vote-selling or coercion — a design principle demonstrated in practice by operational e-voting systems including Swiss Post’s

These requirements are satisfied by a combination of homomorphic encryption (which allows votes to be tallied without decrypting individual ballots) and zero-knowledge range proofs (which allow voters to verify their vote was counted without identifying which vote was theirs).

3.3 Infrastructure and Resilience

The Planet’s Vote's infrastructure is deliberately designed to be unshuttable by any single nation or coalition of nations. This is achieved through:

- Distributed hosting across jurisdictions in at least 12 nations with strong rule-of-law protections for internet infrastructure
- Peer-to-peer fallback protocols that allow the platform to operate via direct device-to-device communication even if centralised infrastructure is taken offline
- Open-source software that can be re-deployed by any party if the primary deployment is compromised
- Cryptographic signing of all data, making tampering immediately and publicly detectable

3.4 The Algorithm Audit System

The trending algorithm is published as open-source code on a public repository with full version history. All parameter changes are announced with a minimum 30-day notice period and subject to a public comment process. An independent Algorithm Audit Committee — appointed by the World Government Council but operationally independent of it — reviews all algorithm decisions and publishes quarterly audit reports.

Part IV: Legal and Political Pathway

4.1 The Legitimacy Question

The most frequent objection to proposals for global democratic governance is the question of legitimacy: by what authority does any body claim to speak for humanity? The Planet’s Vote's answer is straightforward and unprecedented: it derives its authority from the direct, voluntary participation of the largest possible number of human beings, expressing their preferences through a transparent, verifiable process.

This is qualitatively different from the legitimacy claim of any existing international institution. The UN General Assembly derives its legitimacy from the consent of member governments, not from the direct consent of their populations. The Planet’s Vote derives its legitimacy from the direct consent of individuals.

This does not mean The Planet’s Vote's authority is unlimited or automatically binding. In its initial phase, The Planet’s Vote's resolutions are politically and morally authoritative but not legally binding under international law. The legal binding mechanism must be built through a parallel process of treaty ratification by nation-states.

4.2 The Treaty Pathway

The path to legal recognition proceeds through the following stages:

1. Foundational Charter: Drafting and publication of The Planet’s Vote's founding charter, defining the scope of the platform's authority, the structure of the World Government Council, and the rights and obligations of member citizens.
2. Founding Nation Signatories: Identification of 10-15 nation-states willing to be founding signatories — nations that agree to honour The Planet’s Vote supermajority votes on defined issue categories within their jurisdictions. Founding signatories may come from any region of the world; the criteria are democratic governance, a track record of constructive multilateral engagement, and willingness to participate in a genuinely novel democratic experiment. No nations are named here as candidates, as any such list risks creating the impression that The Planet’s Vote is aligned with particular political traditions or regions — a perception fundamentally at odds with the platform’s founding principle that no nation, perspective, or bloc holds a privileged position.
3. UN General Assembly Recognition: Submission of The Planet’s Vote as a recognised civil society platform to the UN General Assembly, seeking observer status and formal acknowledgment of its legitimacy as a global democratic voice.
4. Binding Issue-by-Issue Ratification: For specific issue categories — beginning with planetary defense and pandemic preparedness — negotiation of binding international agreements that formally incorporate The Planet’s Vote supermajority votes into treaty obligations.
5. Full Constitutional Recognition: Over a generational timeframe, the progressive expansion of The Planet’s Vote's binding authority across all planetary-class issue categories, constitutionalised through a global treaty.

4.3 Relationship with Existing Institutions

The Planet’s Vote is not designed to replace the United Nations, the International Court of Justice, the World Health Organization, or any other existing international institution. It is designed to provide these institutions with something they currently lack: a democratic mandate from the population they serve.

In practical terms, this means The Planet’s Vote resolutions on planetary defense, climate, pandemic preparedness, and AI governance are transmitted to the relevant existing institutions as formal mandates from the global citizenry. Those institutions retain their operational and technical expertise. The Planet’s Vote provides the democratic legitimacy that authorises them to act.

> *The relationship between The Planet’s Vote and existing international institutions should be understood as analogous to the relationship between a national parliament and its executive agencies: the parliament provides the mandate, the agencies provide the implementation capacity. Neither can function legitimately without the other.*

Part V: The First Vote — Planetary Defense

5.1 Why Planetary Defense is the Right First Issue

The choice of the first real issue to put before a global democratic vote matters enormously. It must be an issue where the case for global coordination is overwhelming and uncontroversial, where the science is clear, where the cost is manageable relative to the stakes, and where success would demonstrate The Planet’s Vote's value beyond any reasonable doubt.

Planetary defense — specifically, the establishment of a permanent, internationally funded Near-Earth Object monitoring and deflection capability — satisfies all of these criteria.

- The science is unambiguous: asteroid and comet impacts have caused mass extinctions in Earth's past and will do so again without intervention
- The technology works: NASA's DART mission proved kinetic deflection in 2022
- The cost is negligible: a comprehensive global planetary defense system costs approximately $1-2 billion per year — less than 0.003% of global GDP
- The issue is non-ideological: no political philosophy opposes not being struck by an asteroid
- No single nation can do it alone: planetary defense requires global telescope coverage, global early warning, and global coordination of deflection missions

A genuine global vote on planetary defense, achieving a 70%+ supermajority, would produce a mandate that no existing international institution has ever had. It would be politically impossible for the UN, NASA, ESA, and national governments to ignore. It would prove the concept of The Planet’s Vote in a way that no theoretical argument can.

5.2 The Shadow Vote Strategy

Before The Planet’s Vote achieves full legal recognition, a Shadow Vote strategy allows the platform to build its voter base, demonstrate its technical capability, and generate politically significant mandates.

A Shadow Vote is a fully functional, technically rigorous, publicly verifiable vote that is non-binding in international law but carries significant political and moral weight. The strategy proceeds as follows:

6. Technical deployment of the full The Planet’s Vote platform for a single issue vote
7. Open registration to any adult globally with internet access and a verifiable identity credential
8. A quarterly vote on the planetary defense mandate question
9. Full public reporting of results with cryptographic verification
10. Formal submission of the result to the UN General Assembly, NASA, ESA, and relevant national governments

11. Media and civil society campaign framing the result as the first genuine democratic mandate from humanity on a planetary issue

A Shadow Vote achieving participation from 100 million or more voters across all regions, with a strong supermajority for planetary defense funding, would be a historic political event — regardless of its formal legal status.

Part VI: Implementation Roadmap

Phase	Actions and Milestones
Phase 0: Foundation (Months 1-6)	Publish white paper globally. Establish open-source GitHub repository. Convene founding advisory council of governance scholars, cryptographers, and democratic theorists. Begin identity layer technical specification.
Phase 1: Identity (Months 6-18)	Partner with SSI standards bodies (W3C DID Working Group, Worldcoin Foundation). Develop privacy-preserving biometric identity protocol. Pilot with 1 million volunteer registrants across 10+ nations. Security audit by independent cryptographers.
Phase 2: Platform Build (Months 12-24)	Build full The Planet’s Vote platform on open-source stack. Zero-knowledge voting protocol implementation. Distributed infrastructure deployment across 12+ jurisdictions. Algorithm audit system operational. Independent security penetration testing.
Phase 3: Shadow Vote (Month 24-30)	Run first Shadow Vote on planetary defense mandate. Target: 50 million+ registered voters globally. Full public result reporting. Submit to UN General Assembly and major space agencies. Global media campaign.
Phase 4: Treaty Pathway (Months 30-60)	Engage founding nation signatories. Draft The Planet’s Vote Founding Charter. Submit for UN General Assembly observer status. Begin binding treaty negotiations on planetary defense and pandemic preparedness issue categories.
Phase 5: Scale (Year 5+)	Expand registered voter base toward universal adult enrolment. Progressive expansion of binding treaty authority. Full World Government Council elections. Transition from Shadow Votes to binding resolutions on founding signatory issues.

6.1 Funding the Initiative

The initial development of The Planet’s Vote is funded through a combination of philanthropic grants, open-source community contribution, and founding nation-state support. The platform must be — and must be seen to be — independent of any single government, corporation, or billionaire funder. Funding governance is therefore as important as technical governance.

A The Planet’s Vote Foundation, structured as an internationally registered nonprofit with a multi-stakeholder board, will receive and allocate all funding. All financial accounts will be published in real time on a public ledger. No single donor may contribute more than 5% of the annual operating budget, preventing capture by any single interest.

The estimated cost of Phases 0-3 is approximately $45-65 million over 30 months — a sum well within reach of a coordinated global philanthropic effort, particularly given the existential stakes the platform is designed to address.

Part VII: Anticipated Objections and Responses

7.1 "National sovereignty will prevent adoption"

The Planet’s Vote does not ask nations to surrender sovereignty on domestic matters. It asks them to participate in coordinated decision-making on the narrow category of issues that are inherently planetary in scope. No nation is sovereign over an asteroid's trajectory. No nation is sovereign over a supervolcanic eruption's atmospheric effects. The sovereignty objection is most powerful precisely where it matters least — on the issues The Planet’s Vote is designed to address.

7.2 "The digital divide excludes billions"

This objection is taken seriously. In 2026, approximately 3.2 billion people lack reliable internet access. The Planet’s Vote's design must accommodate offline and low-bandwidth participation from the outset — through SMS-based voting protocols, in-person community verification centres in low-connectivity regions, and partnerships with local civil society organisations. Universal participation is a design requirement, not an aspiration. The platform is not legitimate if it structurally excludes the Global South.

7.3 "Misinformation will corrupt the vote"

The trending algorithm's scientific consensus weighting is specifically designed to resist misinformation capture of the agenda. For empirically grounded issues, the algorithm boosts issues where broad scientific consensus exists and downweights issues primarily driven by demonstrably false factual claims. The platform also maintains a public, auditable fact-checking layer for all issues on the active ballot. This does not prevent misinformation — nothing does entirely — but it significantly reduces its ability to drive the planetary agenda.

7.4 "Who guards the guardians?"

This is the most important objection and the one to which The Planet’s Vote's entire technical architecture is the answer. The platform guards itself through radical transparency. Every algorithmic decision is auditable. Every vote is cryptographically verifiable. Every line of code is open source. Every funding transaction is publicly recorded. The Algorithm Audit Committee, the The Planet’s Vote Foundation board, and the World Government Council are all subject to recall votes and public accountability mechanisms. No single actor — including the platform's founders — has unilateral control over any element of the system.

7.5 "This has been tried before and failed"

Previous attempts at global democratic governance have failed for three reasons: they were not genuinely democratic (they represented governments, not people), they lacked the technological infrastructure for direct participation at scale, and they were designed as all-or-nothing replacements for the existing nation-state system rather than as complementary layers. The Planet’s Vote addresses all three failures: it is direct democracy, it is built on 21st-century cryptographic infrastructure, and it is explicitly designed to complement rather than replace existing institutions.

Conclusion: The Necessity of The Planet’s Vote

There is a version of the future in which humanity continues to be governed by 195 separate nation-states, each making decisions based on short electoral cycles and narrow national interest, while the planetary threats that do not respect those nations accumulate toward catastrophe. In that version of the future, the question is not whether a supervolcanic eruption or asteroid impact will occur — it is only when, and whether we will have built the coordination mechanisms to respond.

There is another version of the future. In that version, humanity looked at the tools available to it — the internet, cryptography, mobile communication, artificial intelligence, the accumulated wisdom of democratic theory — and built something new. Not a world government in the sense of a global authority over all human affairs. Something more modest and more powerful: a mechanism through which the people of Earth, speaking together for the first time in history, expressed their collective will on the decisions that determine whether they survive.

The Planet’s Vote is that mechanism. It is technically feasible. It is politically achievable. It is philosophically justified. And given the threats that face this civilisation, it is arguably the most important infrastructure project of the 21st century.

The question is not whether such a platform should exist. The question is whether the people who understand the necessity will act before the necessity becomes catastrophe.

> *We invite every governance scholar, cryptographer, democratic theorist, jurist, technologist, and concerned citizen to join this effort. The Planet’s Vote belongs to humanity. Its development must reflect that from the first day.*

Appendix A: Glossary of Key Terms

Term	Definition
Supermajority	A voting threshold of 66.7% (two-thirds) of participating voters required for any standard resolution to pass under The Planet’s Vote.
Zero-Knowledge Proof	A cryptographic method allowing one party to prove a statement is true without revealing any information beyond the truth of the statement itself.
Self-Sovereign Identity (SSI)	An identity model in which individuals control their own digital credentials without reliance on centralised authorities.
Decentralised Identifier (DID)	A type of globally unique identifier anchored to a public blockchain, controlled by the individual, not by any registrar.
Homomorphic Encryption	Encryption that allows computation on encrypted data without decrypting it, enabling vote tallying without exposing individual ballots.
Quarterly Voting Cycle	The quarterly voting cycle used by The Planet’s Vote. Votes are held up to four times per year, triggered when a minimum of two ratified questions reach the signal threshold.
Emergency Override Protocol	The Planet’s Vote's mechanism for opening a crisis vote within 6 hours of a verified planetary-class threat, bypassing the standard quarterly schedule.
Shadow Vote	A fully functional but non-legally-binding The Planet’s Vote vote, used to build voter base, demonstrate platform capability, and generate political mandates during the pre-treaty phase.
World Government Council	The 17-member (plus Secretary-General) executive body of The Planet’s Vote, elected by regional supermajority, responsible for implementing passed resolutions.
Trending Algorithm	The Planet’s Vote's open-source, publicly auditable system for reviewing proposed questions, confirming scientific ratification, and surfacing those with the highest signal counts to the quarterly ballot.

Appendix B: Relevant Existing Institutions and Frameworks

Institution / Framework	Relevance to The Planet’s Vote
UN Office for Outer Space Affairs (UNOOSA)	Primary UN body for space governance. Natural partner for planetary defense mandate implementation.
International Asteroid Warning Network (IAWN)	Existing voluntary coordination network for NEO threat assessment. Provides technical infrastructure The Planet’s Vote can mandate funding for.
Space Mission Planning Advisory Group (SMPAG)	Coordinates international response planning for NEO threats. Requires binding authority that The Planet’s Vote can provide.
W3C Decentralised Identifier Working Group	Develops open standards for DID infrastructure. Critical technical partner for The Planet’s Vote identity layer.
Antarctic Treaty System (1959)	Proof of concept for cooperative international governance of a global common. Demonstrates feasibility of sovereignty-sharing on planetary issues.
Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (1968)	Model for binding international agreement on an existential risk category. Template for The Planet’s Vote's treaty pathway.
EU eIDAS 2.0 Framework	European digital identity standard. Relevant to The Planet’s Vote identity layer design for European participants.
IPCC (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change)	Scientific consensus body whose findings should feed directly into The Planet’s Vote's algorithm for climate-related issues.
Internet Governance Forum (IGF)	UN forum on internet governance. Potential venue for early The Planet’s Vote legitimacy-building engagement.

Appendix C: Recommended Reading and References

The following works inform the theoretical and technical foundations of The Planet’s Vote:

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To contribute to this initiative:

github.com/PlanetVote/PlanetVote

theplanetsvote.org

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